

gradient and huge flow make it ideal for hydroelectric generation, and almost half of the US's hydroelectric power is generated in its basin.

Manicouagan Lake

Location Quebec province, eastern Canada

This ring-shaped crater lake has been called the eye of Canada after its rough-edged, circular shape on a map. It was formed by the impact of a massive meteor, which measured 3 miles (5 km) across, about 214 million years ago. The original crater was about 60 miles (100 km) across, although the lake now has a diameter of 45 miles (72 km). Mount Babel, on the island in the middle of Manicouagan Lake, marks the crater's central peak, which formed after Earth's crust rebounded from the original impact. The lake drains into Manicouagan River to the south.

▼ TUFA TOWERS ON MONO LAKE

Lake Seneca

Location New York, eastern U.S.

This is the largest of New York's 11 freshwater finger lakes and has a reputation as a superb trout fishery. The lakes are in north-south valleys that were originally eroded by rivers but were later greatly deepened by south-flowing glaciers about 2 million years ago. The deepest point in Lake Seneca is 617 ft (188 m), well below sea level. It is fed by large underground springs, whose currents keep the lake mostly free of ice.

The Hudson River

Location From the Adirondack Mountains to New York, eastern U.S.

Although not especially long, at 315 miles (507 km), this is a river of great contrasts, rising in the sparsely populated Adirondack Mountains

and flowing south to reach one of the world's busiest ports and greatest cities, New York City. A rise in sea level since the last ice age has "drowned" the lower reaches, meaning that almost half of the Hudson's length is tidal. When sea levels were lower, its estuary was 200 miles (320 km) south of New York City, at the edge of the continental shelf.

Mono Lake

Location California, western U.S.

Mono Lake is a shallow, salty water body with no outlet, lying in a basin just east of the Sierra Nevada. The basin is probably 3–4 million years old, and the lake is known to have existed for about 750,000 years. Although no more than 165 ft (50 m) deep now, it has been much deeper in the past. Along parts of the shoreline close to underwater

springs, towers of tufa (a kind of limestone) have formed. The lake's saline water supports a huge population of brine shrimps, which provide good feeding for up to 2 million water birds.

The Rio Grande

Location Southwest U.S. and U.S.-Mexico border

This iconic river forms much of the U.S.-Mexico border. Near its source in the San Juan Mountains of Colorado, it flows as a clear, snow-fed stream before passing through a series of deep canyons near Big Bend, Texas, then sluggishly meandering across a broad floodplain to reach the Gulf of Mexico. At 1,900 miles (3,100 km) long, it is the 20th longest river on Earth, and its drainage basin is vast, but heavy water extraction for agriculture, industry, and domestic use means only 20 percent of its natural discharge reaches the ocean. Nowhere is the river deep, and only small boats can navigate it.

